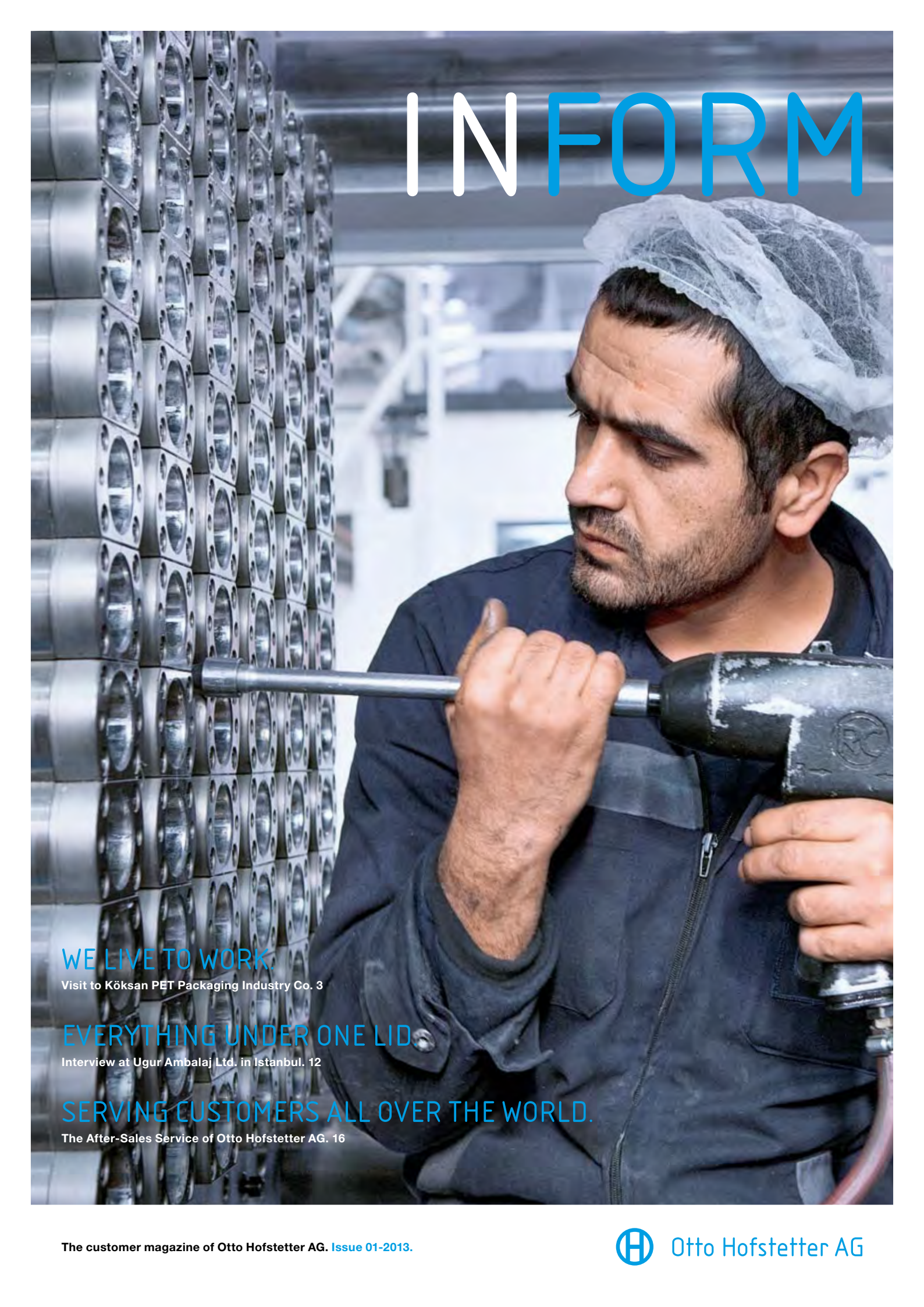


INFORM

A man with a beard, wearing a dark blue work jacket and a white hairnet, is focused on his work. He is using a large, black, industrial power tool with a long metal rod to work on a large, complex metal mold. The mold is made of many interconnected parts, creating a grid-like structure with numerous circular openings. The background is a blurred industrial setting with various pipes and machinery.

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TURKEY AS A CHANCE.



Dear Readers

We've been cooperating with Turkish enterprises for more than 15 years and experienced the development of the nation at the bridge between East and West directly. With growth rates between 5 and 10 per cent in the course of the last ten years, Turkey has become an important sales market and developed globally to an attractive location of industry and commerce. Thanks to the adaptation to European standards the chances for the Turkish economy are steadily increasing. Apart from its dynamic domestic market, Turkey is a connecting link to Central Asia, Arabia and Africa, which are gaining ever more significance. Markets with a promising future to the North, East and South of the country are just a few hours away from Istanbul by air, i.e. within easy reach of the Turkish entrepreneurs, who are traditionally aligned to trade.

In our contacts with Turkey we feel the dynamism of the private sector and are amazed time and again how quickly big investments are made. The modernization of the industry progresses at a rapid pace and calls for suitable technologies. For us this means that we can't just sit back and do nothing, but that we must further improve the acknowledged high quality of our injection moulds. The aspiring Turkish packaging industry confronts us with major challenges, but at the same time opens up interesting prospects for our enterprise. Moreover, it brings us in touch with countries and markets which we Central Europeans would otherwise approach with some hesitance.

In this issue of "Inform" we present you two successful Turkish entrepreneurs. Both of them stand for the untiring endeavour of Turkey to advance, and reflect the resulting dynamism of the economy. We wish you enlightening reading.

Yours, Otto Hofstetter



Cover.

An employee of Köksan changing the format of a Hofstetter mould.

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A portrait of Murat Kökoglul, CEO of Köksan PET Packaging Industry Co., speaking. He is a middle-aged man with dark hair, wearing a dark blue suit, white shirt, and a blue patterned tie. He is gesturing with both hands while speaking. In the background, the Turkish flag is visible on the left, and a white chair is partially visible behind him.

"WE LIVE
TO WORK."

Köksan PET Packaging Industry Co. is Turkey's biggest producer of PET preforms. The family business in **Gaziantep** provides work to more than **400 persons**. "Inform" has met **CEO Murat Kökoglul** and discussed his enterprise, objectives and visions with him.

Murat Kökoglul, CEO of Köksan PET Packaging Industry Co., took the company over from his father and now leads it to a new era.

Mr Kökçü: Please give us a few facts about Köksan.

Köksan is a privately owned company. There are currently 400 employees working for Köksan, which runs a continuous production schedule seven days a week with three shifts per day. In 2012, our company had a turnover of 200 million dollars with an average growth of over 20 per cent every year over the last decade.

"IF YOU WANT TO SUCCEED, YOU MUST STAY IN YOUR HOMETOWN."

Murat Kökçü

Last year, Köksan produced 6 billion product pieces. There are three main types of preforms that we have: Twist-off, PCO, Snap-on and Edible Oil Preforms. Each neck type preform production is completed with the same type of closure manufacturing. Thus to fully connect and complete the packaging chain, Köksan started producing closures under the brand EUROCAP™ in 2007. Our present capacity is eight closure lines; our target is to double that by 2013. We have currently more than 27 injection machines. Köksan is probably the world's largest preform producer under one roof.

Köksan was founded in 1968. What are the milestones in the company history?

The real foundation of the company was in 1900 when my grandfather started to trade with food. In 1985 my father took over the business. Apart from food trading he was also

producing pickles at that time. Therefore he decided to enter into the metal packaging and metal tin production industry. As soon as the management foresaw that the PET business had a great opportunity for major growth within the packaging industry in 1997, it began producing PET jars and bottles in Istanbul. The company later moved the PET producing facilities from Istanbul to be centralized in Gaziantep. In 2003 we started the preform and in 2007 the closure production.

In 2001 you moved from Istanbul to Gaziantep. What was the motivation?

Gaziantep is our hometown; our family tree history goes more than five generations back to Gaziantep. We always knew that one day we would move the production to Gaziantep and become an important part of the city's economy. We take pride in being the local manufacturer which turns to be a global brand. Köksan exports to more than 60 countries in the world, making Gaziantep a global city which is at everyone's lips at the moment.

Within 44 years Köksan became a main national player in the PET- and Packaging-Industry. What is the formula of your success?

As Confucius said thousands years ago: "Choose a job you love, and you will never have to work a day in your life." Even now, after years of doing this job, most of our staff – including me – live to work. We are sharing the same ideology that Köksan is not a workplace but rather a part of our life. We all have a mission to complete and move ahead. Our mission is to better the world by revolutionizing the global packaging



Köksan produces high-grade PET preforms and relies on Swiss quality for its injection moulds.



In mould service and maintenance the specialists of Köksan can count on competent support from Otto Hofstetter AG.

industry, utilizing innovative technology to produce the most efficient and environmentally friendly products.

What is the benefit of being a client of Köksan?

I think some years ago, while being interviewed by one of the magazines, I said: "One of the reasons of our success is a combination of top-notch Swiss technology and Turkish flexibility." We produce highest quality products. But despite the growth we are still thinking that maximum flexibility provided to any customer is the main key to success. Minimalizing bureaucratic procedures, optimization of on-time solutions, fast service and on-time replies are the main benefits of our customers.

Custom-made colours, flexibility in delivery and creative solutions, treating a small unknown water bottler at the same level as you would treat a very important multinational brand client, providing equal service level to all our customers regardless of their geographical location – all these are benefits our customers get.

On your website you talk about providing quality products. What are the relevant factors to reach this goal?

To be successful in the perform production there are only two key points to focus: the mould and the machine. In

2003, we bought the first Otto Hofstetter mould. Its quality and shelf life are terrific: 15 million cycles since putting it into operation. Due to our high-quality equipment all of our products are held to the highest quality standards, providing our clients the reliability and accountability that is vital to the time-sensitive packaging industry. Our methods are continually improving as we strive to remain a leader in the plastic packaging industry.

Is Swiss quality a speciality to afford?

My understanding of Swiss quality is trust, reliability and always on time. But not all Swiss companies have the same view. It's not given by being located in Switzerland, it has to be the company's philosophy. Another attitude that is very important is confidentiality. For example, with Otto Hofstetter we don't have to have contracts that regulate every detail, confidentiality is part of their fundamental philosophy.

Otto Hofstetter is one of your partners. In which fields do you work with the Swiss partner?

Otto Hofstetter is not only our supplier but – as you said – our partner. We work together on new product developments, light-weighting projects, process optimization and in many other fields.

MTR TECHNOLOGY.

The MTR® process eliminates the solid-state post condensation (SSP) process and leads to substantial energy savings. It reduces investment, operating and maintenance costs, has a higher raw material yield and results in products of superior quality. The MTR® process is based on Uhde Inventa-Fischer's proprietary 2-reactor technology which uses the patented ESPREE® and DISCAGE® reactors to obtain the desired high-melt viscosities.

In summer 2013, Köksan will commission a top-modern plant for the production of PET granulate. This facility is expected to largely cover the raw material demand of Turkey.

Köksan is a family-owned and -run company like Otto Hofstetter. In what way does this fact influence the co-operation?

The structural similarities of both companies have a positive influence on eliminating unnecessary steps towards target achievement. I do believe that the common characteristic of both Köksan and Otto Hofstetter is being result-oriented.

"THE WORLD IS A GLOBAL VILLAGE."

Murat Kökoglu

Is being family-owned the organization form of the future?

Your company can grow easily as a family business. But in the long term you must have a corporate structure. To keep the company on its track, family members have to be in the board but the daily business should be done by specialists. Furthermore, we don't know if the next generation is interested in continuing the firm. I think if you want your company to grow, you have to give it a corporate structure.

What do you think, where are the growing markets of the future? What industry sectors offer the best opportunities?

PET packaging will remain the strongest in the beverage sector for the next few decades. However, environmental awareness may force us to use more and more "bio" solutions and recycled materials. Köksan has been a part of this global trend for years by providing innovative bio PET options to its customers worldwide. As to your question about the growing markets of the future, we believe that trade and business between emerging markets is the future, and in fact it has started reshaping the global competition. This development is bound to upset complacent attitudes in mature economies about long-held dominance in strategy, innovation and talent.

In terms of markets, I think Africa and Latin America provide great opportunities. The population is high and all businesses are growing, not only the food and beverage sector. Entering the markets is not a company strategy, it's just a logical step in the way the world is developing.

By approaching your plant, the building site of your PET resin plant can't be overlooked. What can you tell us about the project?

The decision to build this PET resin plant is not just a milestone on our company's level but has a significant importance for the economy of Turkey. Our investment will change

the position of the country from a net PET importer to an exporter. With the establishing of the second PET line Turkey will turn into an important PET exporter in the world. With the first line Köksan will produce 216,000 tonnes of PET resin per year, which will cover the whole domestic consumption of PET. With the second line that we put into action in 2016 we produce again 216,000 tonnes, which go into export.

What are the key figures of the project?

First phase is an investment of 150 million dollars. We started with the planning in 2010. One year later we decided to implement our concept and in summer 2013 the plant will be inaugurated. To meet this deadline, the 600 construction workers keep working hard. They have to handle 4000 tonnes of steel and build over 10 kilometres of pipelines. The maximum height of the building is 52 metres. When I visit the site, I feel like seeing my own kid growing.

Actually there are only four other companies in the world using the same technology for a PET resin production. Provided by a German company, the MTR technology is based on a 2-reactor system, which offers a wide range of economic, commercial and environmental benefits. Guided by the same philosophy as with the purchase of our machines and moulds, we haven't been looking for the cheapest solution but for the most innovative and most sustainable. It's a long-term investment, even our children will have to live with that plant one day.

Let's be visionary, what is the next major step of Köksan?

One of our company's dream is to produce terephthalic acid (PTA). If you want to grow, you better expand your business upstream as we did: from bottles to preform, from preform to resin. And in a more general point of view our vision should always be: "What can I do for the world?"

Mr Kökoglu, thank you very much for your time. We wish you and your company all the best for the future.



The history of the Köksan enterprise starts around 1900 in Gaziantep with the trade in foodstuffs. In 1997, the company takes up the production of PET bottles. Today, Köksan is one of Turkey's most important makers of PET preforms in Gaziantep, with a second operation in Hendek. This summer, Köksan will commission the first production line for PET granulate in Gaziantep. A doubling of the capacity is scheduled for 2016.

www.koksan.com

TURKEY IS SPEEDING UP.

Economically speaking, Turkey was on the ground a mere twelve years ago. Today the country at the Bosphorus shines with solid growth and a robust economy. Hardly any other national economy experiences such an atmosphere of awakening. This holds not only chances, but also some risks.

Turkey has been bursting with self-confidence for years. An explanation for this is not least the submitted proof of solid economic performance. Mind you, the global economic and financial crisis hasn't spared the sixteenth-biggest national economy either, with the effect that Turkey, after a long period of high growth (the economy expanded by approx. 6 per cent annually between 2002 and 2008), slithered also into a recession in the crisis year 2009. However, the country came back on its feet again surprisingly quickly and for years has been well in the lead in terms of growth, not only ahead of the EU, but of most other world regions.

It's anything but a matter of course that Turkey has been praised for years as a "boom market" or the "tiger state of Eurasia". This because, in the second half of the 1990s, it was referred to as the "sick man on the Bosphorus". At that time the country suffered from a hyperinflation. The smallest banknote was the one of 100,000 lira and the Guinness Book of Records for 1995, 1996 and 1999 listed the Turkish currency as the one of the lowest value worldwide. Investors steered well clear of the country and anyone getting cash in Turkish lira tried hard to change this money into a hard currency as quickly as possible.



The break in 2001.

What happened since, why has Turkey been enjoying such an impressive robustness for years? The answer lies in the serious Turkish financial crisis of 2001. Under the leadership of Kemal Dervis, then Minister for Economic Affairs, and with the support of the International Monetary Fund (IMF), the predicament was turned into a radical new start. Apart from rigorous cuts in expenditure and the pushing ahead of privatization, the concept also foresaw the restructuring of the banking sector which was severely distorted at the time due to earlier political interventions. Inefficient financial companies were shut down and numerous institutions provided with new capital. The banks were subjected to rigorous supervision, the exchange rate was made more flexible and the Central Bank politically independent.

The programme was entirely successful. After the recession in 2001, Turkey was on an expansion course again already one year later. Thanks to spending cuts and income

from privatizations the deficit of the government budget and the debt came down rapidly and the inflation, previously at record level, decreased to single-digit percentages.

Demographic trump cards.

Under the pressure of the crisis, therefore, already a decade ago Turkey implemented many reforms which European peripheral states currently face. But this isn't the only reason why a growing number of enterprises feel attracted to Turkey. Of high interest are also the size and dynamism of the market. Turkey has not only about 75 million inhabitants with a steadily increasing buying power, but also a very young population. The average age is below 30 years. In view of the rapid growth the United Nations estimate the population to reach approx. 92 million by 2050.

Apart from the demographic pluses there are geostrategic advantages. Turkey has always been the natural link between Europe, the Near East and Central Asia. After the

"WESTERN
COMPANIES CAN DO
GOOD BUSINESS HERE
IF THEY ABIDE BY
OUR RULES."

Deniz Klanten,
owner and General Manager of
Alp Chemicals SA



ALP-CHEMICALS S.A.

Alp Chemicals SA represents European and overseas companies exclusively, among them also Otto Hofstetter AG for the segment of PET. The product range comprises machines and periphery for plastics processing as well as industrial raw materials and additives for the chemical industry. Apart from importing, storing and distributing raw materials and spare parts, the team of experienced specialists provides also a technical after-sales service. Alp Chemicals SA has its head office in Istanbul, two subsidiaries in Turkey and a branch office in Switzerland.

www.alpchemicals.com.tr

founding of the Republic by Atatürk in the year 1923, the focus of the foreign and economic policy was almost entirely on the West. Since about a decade, however, an intensified opening can be observed towards the formerly neglected neighbouring states to the East. This reorientation sometimes referred to as the “Neo-Ottoman Renaissance” has the consequence that Turkey’s dependence on the EU with its currently minimal economic dynamism has decreased steadily.

The newly growing middle class is a further reason for the atmosphere of departure that reigns in Turkey. Family businesses striving for progress, geographically often anchored in the supposed hinterland of Central Anatolia and therefore sometimes called the “Anatolian Tigers”, are already now responsible for more than half of all exports. In parallel to their social ascent the towns see the spreading of a new Anatolian middle class. This doesn’t always happen without tensions because the old elite in its western and secular ways sees itself threatened by the religiously rather conservative social climbers hungry for success. It is a fact, however, that the Turkish society has become more mobile and open in the past years.

Economic imbalances.

The above strengths, however, cannot conceal that the Turkish economy is also characterized by numerous weaknesses. One handicap – which may be an opportunity for some resourceful Swiss enterprises – is the circumstance that a wide range of goods made in Turkey still consists of labour-intensive products of low or average technology. The urgently required development towards innovative high-grade industrial products of much increased value is only starting to take place.

Ambitious objectives.

Another weakness of the labour market is the low employment level, i.e. the low share of those gainfully employed in relation to the ones fit for work. While this quota is at nearly 70 per cent in the EU, it is below 50 per cent in Turkey. Hereby it is striking that mainly women are only minimally integrated in the earning process. Their quota of employment is only about 30 per cent.

But these and a series of other problems make little difference to the fact that the history of the last ten years – a period of exceptional political stability – represents a success story for the Turkish economy.



The per-capita income has trebled to more than 10,000 dollars in the last decade. And the country has already set itself the target of advancing to the club of the world's ten biggest national economies with an income of 25,000 dollars per head by the year 2023, when the Republic celebrates its one-hundredth anniversary. Much can happen in the intervening period, of course, so that no forecasts to be taken too seriously can be made at this stage. What is clearly reflected in Ankara's ambitious objectives, however, is the unbroken self-consciousness of an economic power which claims its place on the global stage.

Mediator between East and West.

What are the prospects? Economically, the indications are that the process of catching up will continue for some considerable time. Politically, signs of a certain arrogance are apparent after the more than ten years of absolute power of Prime Minister Erdogan's AKP. The old and frequently reappearing suspicion that the Islamic-conservative AKP might pursue a "secret agenda" and aim for a God state has not come true so far. The party doesn't conceal its religious identity in any way, but neither do the Christian-democratic people's parties in Switzerland or Germany.

Serious radical changes as they are currently under way in various Arab countries are not to be expected in Turkey. As imperfect as the Turkish democracy may be, it is too established for a revolution. For many Arabs and North Africans who only recently got rid of their authoritarian rulers, Turkey serves as a model of how an Islamic society can be quite compatible with the principles of democracy and market economy. As a Muslim and at the same time Western-secular state, Turkey is particularly suitable to play a conciliatory role between East and West. This is why Turkey gains in importance not only economically, but also geopolitically.

Author: Thomas Fuster. Correspondent of the "Neue Zürcher Zeitung" and reporting regularly on Turkey.



"BIG PLAYERS OF
THE PLASTICS TRADE
WILL SOON DETECT
THE POTENTIAL
OF TURKEY."

Semih Dogan,
CEO Tepro Makine, Istanbul



tepro
technology in progress

The company domiciled in Istanbul is specialized in consultancy, the sale and technical servicing of machinery, automation systems and peripheral equipment for the plastics industry. With a team of more than 50 employees Tepro represents Otto Hofstetter AG in the field of packaging, and further major European producers in Turkey, the Middle East and some countries on the Balkans.

www.tepro.com.tr

EVERYTHING UNDER ONE LID.



Ugur Ambalaj, domiciled in a suburb of **Istanbul**, produces under the brand name of **Cupplast**. The young company makes packaging articles for foodstuffs and progresses on the basis of a fascinating concept. **Mr Salih Ercan, General Manager of Ugur Ambalaj**, in the interview.

Mr Ercan, how did Ugur Ambalaj originate?

The company was founded in the year 2001 by the Turkish grocery concern Ülker. The Management wondered how it could successfully place its margarine – a significant category in its portfolio of more than 3560 products – in the

market. One of the conclusions was for the concern itself to enter into the packaging business, and this with the in-mould labelling technique. At that time I worked in the purchasing department of Ülker and was put in charge of the venture. In 2006 Ülker sold us the company.



"WE PRODUCE WHAT
THE MARKET WANTS."

Salih Ercan

Salih Ercan, CEO of Ugur Ambalaj, follows a successful production concept with his foodstuffs packaging company.

And how is your present relationship with Ülker?

The foodstuffs concern is our most important customer now as before. In our first years we produced for Ülker exclusively, and today the concern still absorbs a handsome 60 per cent of our capacity.

How high is the capacity?

Ugur Ambalaj employs about 190 persons. We produce on 21 machines in three shifts and process roughly 4000 tonnes of polypropylene granulate per year. Right now we

operate mostly 8-impression moulds, in the lid production also stack moulds. In this way we achieve an annual output of approximately 200 million packaging products. It isn't a gigantic quantity, but we're happy.

Any potential for increasing?

We assess our performance on a daily basis. With the present machinery and equipment we can only increase the capacity by expanding to round-the-clock operation on seven days per week. We are currently aligning our organization in this direction.

What are the specialities of Ugur Ambalaj?

Considering our orientation and the historic connection to Ülker we are specialized in thin-walled packaging articles of the sizes 250ml and 500ml. Two-kilo containers have been supplementing our wide spectrum for a year. Our real strength, however, is our operating methodology and our concept.

Can you tell us a bit more about these?

As we understand it, a packaging product must always satisfy two criteria to be successful. In the first place it should be as functional as possible and easy to produce. Secondly, it needs the acceptance of the mostly female end-consumers.

What does this mean on the technical side?

We have been abiding by the "one-lid principle" for some time. This means: the entire packaging range of one filling size fits under one type of lid. With this basically simple measure we are attractive to our customers and also make life easier for ourselves. Our customers can be confident that every new packaging product will go trouble-free through the filling and lidding processes and we save in the costs of the injection mould.

How do you find new moulds for packaging articles?

Thanks to my past with Ülker, where I cooperated closely with Marketing, this world isn't alien to me. Moreover, whenever abroad I try to visit the food departments of supermarkets to get an overview of current shapes and colours. And I attend trade fairs to be on the ball at all times.

How do you proceed as regards development?

Initially it's always an investment on our part. We translate the ideas, come up with samples and keep refining the new mould until it meets our expectations. In a next step we make prototypes and present them to our customer. If he isn't fully convinced, we offer him a pilot lot of say ten thou-

sand pieces. He can fill them with e.g. his margarine and place them in the chiller cabinets on a trial basis. If the lady customers go for them, we're almost certain of an order and the investment pays dividends.

"SOMETHING'S ONLY SUCCESSFUL IF IT'S SIMPLE FOR ALL THOSE INVOLVED."

Salih Ercan

An example explaining our procedures: We negotiated with a Syrian producer of margarine about packaging with in-mould labelling. He was reluctant for a long time because he thought the price was too high in relation to the product to be filled. Without him being aware we designed and developed a packaging product and supplied him a test lot. The product sold very well. Ever since we've been delivering these products to Syria in large quantities – once per week and regardless of the hostilities that are going on there at the moment. We invested much time and money in our customer's future, and his order is now a part of our success.

What are your experiences with the "one-lid principle"?

We put the idea in more concrete terms in 2007 and discussed the technical feasibility with suppliers. A Turkish partner was also convinced of the concept and made first tests with us. Already one year later, i.e. in 2008, we adjusted our product range to the new system. It is a success for our customers and ourselves. The foodstuff producers can launch new shapes on the market more frequently and quicker, and our production is more cost-effective.

Punctuality is mandatory for Ugur Ambalaj and its customers, which is why Swiss reliability is resorted to in production.

What criteria should a partner meet in order to cooperate with you?

It's very important to me that he understands my needs and those of the market, because we can only be successful if we know the requirements – in our case the ones of the food industry – and are able to offer solutions. If a partner is only interested in selling his moulding machine or his mould, it isn't a good situation to start from. Apart from this we attach much importance to our partners being open, honest and absolutely reliable. We don't even discuss quality, it's simply a must.

Otto Hofstetter AG is one of your partners. What characterizes the company?

The injection moulds of Otto Hofstetter AG are of excellent quality. It isn't for nothing that the company enjoys such a good reputation in the packaging trade. Whoever runs moulds from Uznach on his moulding machines can't do anything wrong.

"ONE MUSTN'T SELL HIS SOLUTION, BUT EXPLAIN THE SOLUTION'S CHANCES."

Salih Ercan

Where do you see the biggest challenge in the future?

The development of the prices worries me. Thin-walled packaging items used to be regarded as high-tech, but today they're just bulk products. Accordingly the customers are no longer willing to pay any price for them. I can understand this. Let's look at the cost ratio between palm

Salih Ercan is in close contact with his suppliers to ensure that they understand his business and actively participate in it.





Ugur Ambalaj moulds about 200 million food packaging products under the “Cupplast” label each year.

oil for the margarine production and PP granulate for the packaging: PP is twice as expensive. Something's simply wrong if the raw material for the packaging box costs more than the raw material for the content. We should always be conscious of this ratio in future developments.

In what countries can packaging articles from your production be found in the chiller cabinets?

With Ülker being our main customer, the lion's share of our production stays in Turkey. But we also export to Finland, Romania, Bulgaria, Syria, Iraq and smaller quantities to Iran, Uzbekistan and Saudi Arabia.

In which countries do you see the biggest potential?

Finland is a European country I supply to. Quite obviously we should sell more in these countries. But in Europe every-

body's on a diet. In the East, on the other hand, people are still ready to eat. I prefer to go eastward.

Mr Ercan, we wish you every success with Ugur Ambalaj and thank you sincerely for this interview.

cupplast

Ugur Ambalaj offers PP packaging mouldings for the foodstuffs industry under the label of “Cupplast”. Hereby the company established in Istanbul relies on the thin-wall and in-mould labelling techniques. The spectrum comprises mostly packaging products for margarine, cream cheese and other dairy products, ice and chocolate cream. Ugur Ambalaj's biggest customer is the Turkish grocery concern Ülker. The company was set up in 2001 and currently employs a workforce of more than 190.

www.ugurpack.com

SERVING CUSTOMERS ALL OVER THE WORLD.

Otto Hofstetter AG has been operating a Technical Centre **for over 15 years**. The **specialized team** has a co-responsibility for the **quality of the new moulds**, supports customers if technical problems arise and cooperates actively in the **development of novel packaging concepts**. With its extremely mobile Service Engineers, Otto Hofstetter AG is **always very near to its customers** wherever they may be on the globe.





Patrick Steinegger and his team in the After-Sales Service of Otto Hofstetter AG are on their way around the globe for their customers.

A world map hangs on the wall at his workstation. The little flags marking the intervention places of his team are spread from Vladivostok (westward) to San Francisco and from Helsinki to Buenos Aires. "My people are on their way at least twice a month. They see to it that our customers can produce quickly at full capacity." Patrick Steinegger is in charge of the After-Sales Service Technical Centre of Otto Hofstetter AG. His eight colleagues and he are the technical interface between internal development and external production.

With their versatile, top-modern machinery and equipment they meet two internal tasks. On the one hand they test the finished moulds and on the other they are actively involved in the new development of moulds and packaging concepts. As Service Engineers they then support our customers in the commissioning of moulds or if irregularities come up during production.

Link between customer and the works.

By After-Sales Service (ASS), Otto Hofstetter AG means the comprehensive aftercare of its moulds and of course also of the customers after a mould delivered and commissioned. Among the main activities of the ASS are spare parts supplies, interventions by Service Engineers, training and telephone support in case of technical questions.

Organizational improvisation.

Many mould manufacturers have difficulties in organizing their service performance and technical care of the moulds after the sale and delivery. In most companies an autonomously organized service team is not used to capacity on account of the company size and the number of supplied moulds, and is therefore impossible to be funded.

The logical consequence: toolmakers from the assembly department are called upon for service interventions at the customers' and in their absence the sales or technical personnel has to answer technical questions next to doing their daily work.

"Such an organization functions to a limited degree only. Moreover, the customer satisfaction suffers because most of the provided services are improvised," explains Stefan Zatti. The Sales and Marketing Manager of Otto Hofstetter AG heads the company's entire ASS organization. An autonomous service team, therefore, is a must for enterprises which sell their products worldwide. "The customer increasingly assesses us on the basis of this performance."

Team of specialists.

In 1998, Otto Hofstetter's ASS department started with one Service Engineer who devoted himself fully to the aftercare of Hofstetter moulds. The measure attracted much interest from the customers. It took only a few weeks for the demand to increase to an extent that this fellow worker was wanted in China, South America and elsewhere at the same time. This prompted us to gradually recruit more competent service personnel and also expand the scope of performance.

Autonomous operation.

As time went, training on moulds in Uznach or at the clients' works as well as many other tasks became part of the programme. In a further step the spare parts and overhauling business was separated from the new-moulds activities. Today this area relies on dedicated specialists exclusively, which enables us to meet an important need of our customers. In parallel with these organizational adjustments we generously expanded our ASS Technical Centre with new machinery and equipment for mould trials and acceptance tests. By now we operate six injection moulding machines of different manufacturers and satisfy the requirements of this special department to the fullest extent. "The ASS department of Otto Hofstetter AG currently employs about 15 persons," explains Patrick Steinegger. "But the Management is already planning a further expansion." His team is additionally strengthened by the Service Technicians of the commercial agents in different countries. All of these have received training in Uznach and effectively support our own ASS specialists in the particular countries.

THE MOULDING MACHINES:

- Arburg Allrounder 470S
- Netstal SynErgy 1000 with extra transverse injection unit for multi-layer applications (co-injection)
- Netstal SynErgy 1750 for PAC standard sampling
- Engel e-motion 180 for co-injection PAC applications with second injection unit arranged vertically
- Engel e-motion 280 for PAC standard sampling
- Netstal SynErgy 4200 for PAC standard sampling



Equipped with the most modern machines, the ASS Technical Centre is responsible for the quality of the moulds and involves itself actively in the development of packaging innovations.



The Service Engineers of Otto Hofstetter AG are always available to their customers: from the first call right to the series production on the shop floor.

In charge of quality.

Prior to delivery to the customer, each mould is thoroughly tested in the Technical Centre. Hereby the real technical circumstances at the customers' are simulated as far as possible. Granulate, cycle time and technical specifications are applied on a one-to-one scale. The test results are also communicated to the development experts who attend to possibly required mould improvements. It is only after the achievement of perfect results that a mould is made ready for despatch.

Service around the globe.

Patrick Steinegger's team in the ASS Technical Centre assists the customers also when the moulds are finally put in operation or if any non-conformities are experienced. A side effect of this is that these team members are rather well-seasoned travellers. They are the troubleshooters from the customer's first telephone call right up to the moment when the mould provides its full output again on the spot.

Plans for the future.

"'From reaction to action' is the Management's slogan," discloses Patrick Steinegger. "We want to be at the customer's already before a possible damage occurs." Otto Hofstetter intends to achieve this goal with preventive inspections, service contracts or also complete monitoring and care of the moulds at the customers'. "Everything always under the aspect of our customers being able to use our moulds to full capacity so that they can contribute their share to the owner's success." To Patrick Steinegger this is also the objective of his team's endeavours: maximum customer satisfaction.

HOFSTETTER SHENZHEN OFFICIALLY OPENED.

December 2012 saw the official opening within a familiar frame. Representatives of local authorities, customers, persons from the head office and the company owner Mr Otto Hofstetter attended the traditional festivities.

In the meantime the gradual training of the local workers and the recruitment of additional employees continues rapidly and benefits from the active support of the headquarters in Switzerland.

The team of Otto Hofstetter Shenzhen Ltd. is now ready to cope with simpler service work at the Chinese customers' on the spot. If more comprehensive work like e.g. an overhaul of a hotrunner is necessary, the mould is returned to the Service Centre where all jobs and tests can be carried out under optimal conditions.

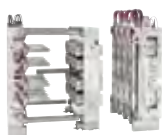


欧拓模具设备(深圳)有限公司
Otto Hofstetter Shenzhen Ltd.



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